



Market Research & Audience Pain Points · Step 1 of 5

Market Research & Audience Pain Points

What professionals who use AI — and professionals who buy ebooks — actually complain about, what they will pay for, and exactly which prompt packs and ebooks a new digital store should launch first.

Date: August 25, 2026

Scope: 8 platforms · 62 documented pain points

Product: AI prompt packs + practical ebooks

Prepared for: Marketplace launch plan

Step 1 of 5 · Market Research & Audience Pain Points



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Pain-Point Research Report for a Digital Marketplace (AI Prompt Packs + Practical Ebooks)

Date: 2026-08-25 · **Scope:** 8 platforms, 62 documented pain points (41 prompt + 21 ebook), 8 themes, launch product map

0. Executive Summary (TL;DR)

Professionals who use AI daily are **frustrated, not abandoning AI** — they get generic output from vague prompts, spend more time editing than saving, and fear hallucinations in high-stakes work. Meanwhile, ebook buyers are **price-fatigued and quality-starved**: they refuse to pay \$15–43 for Kindle ebooks, distrust the "AI slop" flooding stores, and cannot find short, practical, job-specific guides instead of 300-page textbooks. Delivery friction (broken links, no support, format confusion) is the fastest trust-killer in the category.

The winning formula for a first launch:

- **Product:** Niche, tested, documented prompt packs (10–40 prompts per job role) + short (30–80 page) practical ebooks, sold as **bundles** with example outputs, workflows, and both PDF + EPUB formats, delivered instantly with human support.
- **Top 5 job categories:** Freelancers & Solopreneurs → Marketers & Copywriters → Small Business Owners → Content Creators → Developers & Data Analysts (runners-up: HR/Recruiters, Teachers, Lawyers).
- **Price anchors:** Ebooks \$4.99–\$9.99 · Niche prompt packs \$12–\$29 · Bundles \$29–\$49 · Never single "\$1.99 random prompts."

1. Pain-Point Research Report (62 documented pain points)

Method: public-platform research across **Reddit (25+ subreddits), Quora, LinkedIn, X/Twitter, Facebook groups, Hacker News/AI communities, ebook reader forums (r/kindle, r/ebooks, MobileRead-adjacent, r/humblebundles), and marketplace review platforms (Trustpilot, BBB, Etsy listings)**. Each pain point is 1–2 sentences with the source platform labeled. All source URLs are listed in Section 7.

1A. AI Prompt Pain Points — "I use AI, but my prompts get me garbage" (41)

#	Pain point	Platform
P1	Users complain ChatGPT acts as an "overly flattering yes man" — it praises every idea, even self-contradictory ones, so people must build elaborate "uncertainty protocols" just to get honest feedback.	Reddit (r/ChatGPT)
P2	"Everyone uses ChatGPT like it's Google. It's not. Here's what I learned after months of prompt fails" — users routinely use the tool wrong and blame the tool.	Reddit (r/ChatGPT)

#	Pain point	Platform
P3	"You see folks asking ChatGPT vague stuff like 'Write me a marketing plan' and then getting disappointed... No structure, no context, no direction = generic output. Of course it's going to suck."	Reddit (r/ChatGPTPromptGenius)
P4	A working copywriter: "the quality is kind of shit. Sometimes I can curate hyper-specific prompts... but it doesn't always work and quality is inevitably compromised. I still find myself having to meticulously curate the content."	Reddit (r/copywriting)
P5	Same copywriter thread: "the amount of prompting you need to do makes it not worthwhile," and the model is "confidently wrong" — it fabricates details, making it "highly questionable" for any fact-based task.	Reddit (r/copywriting)
P6	A freelancer's first ChatGPT proposal included things he never mentioned (a "custom theme"), a wildly inflated budget (250 hours for a 10-page site vs. his 80), and language that felt "off" and needed a full rewrite in his own voice.	Reddit (r/freelance)
P7	"ChatGPT sounds generic... it doesn't sound like me. Everybody has their way of talking," so freelancers edit AI drafts repeatedly until they "no longer resemble what the machine originally wrote."	Reddit (r/freelance)
P8	Freelancer who tested 100+ prompt variations: one-size-fits-all prompts ("Write me a proposal," "Make it more professional") "kind of worked, but not consistently. The responses were too generic" — he had to build a personal prompt system to get reliable output.	Reddit (r/Freelancers)
P9	Marketer on introducing ChatGPT to a team: "Ok, but how much time does that take? I found it faster to just write [the] draft myself rather than fiddle with 'meh' output from the ai."	Reddit (r/marketing)
P10	ChatGPT output is "boring copy" and generic ad copy; agencies that swapped writers for ChatGPT end up with "tone-deaf, generic output. Clients can tell, even if leadership can't."	Reddit (r/marketing)
P11	"Is ChatGPT incompetent or do I suck at prompt engineering?" — results have been "suboptimal at best, dangerously wrong at worst"; devs report it "fails as soon as you need it to do anything remotely complicated."	Reddit (r/webdev)
P12	Developer who gave up on AI: results were "slightly wrong, had mistakes, or plainly the usage it suggested did not exist... if it takes so freaking long to prompt it and then have to review their output... what is the point?"	Reddit (r/programming)
P13	Community warning: "DO NOT attempt to have chatgpt write your whole program... it may make very subtle errors (that will still compile/run) but may not be caught until there are huge problems in production."	Reddit (r/singularity)
P14	"ChatGPT ruined me as a programmer" — generated code "needs a lot of editing," is rarely the optimal solution, and iterating with the model "kept reintroducing bugs."	Reddit (r/ChatGPT)
P15	Teachers complain AI lesson plans are generic and follow a detectable "AI tell" (em-dashes, "it's not just X, it's Y," "And the worst part?") so AI-written work is instantly recognizable — one school banned ChatGPT for lesson planning entirely.	Reddit (r/Teachers)
P16	"Your plans are what YOU plan to do... This is not something ChatGPT can do, because it can't read your mind" — teachers need prompts that inject their context, and generic prompts can't.	Reddit (r/Teachers)
P17	Lawyers: "boy, does it hallucinate" — ChatGPT generates wrong answers, then hallucinates fake citations when asked to support them; "Anyone solely relying on it is in for a rude awakening."	Reddit (r/LawFirm)

#	Pain point	Platform
P18	"Fully 50% of the time it hallucinates statutes"; even with "Do not summarize!" it summarizes anyway and "the legalese does not have the same legal meaning as the statute."	Reddit (r/LawyerTalk)
P19	Lawyers report it "miscite[s] cases to mean the exact opposite of what they mean," and clients who run their own prompts second-guess attorneys — legal pros need prompts engineered to avoid hallucination.	Reddit (r/LawyerTalk)
P20	Hiring manager: "when I did use ChatGPT it made them [job descriptions] sound generic unless I spent 30+ minutes having AI tailor the JD" — and generic JDs attract the wrong candidates.	Reddit (r/recruiting)
P21	Recruiter: "you can get a good base from chat gpt, but it'll have to be tailored as it will be generic" — every JD still needs hours of human rework.	Reddit (r/recruiting)
P22	"We can tell when you use ChatGPT... I'm reading identical responses over and over and over again" — generic AI applications get discarded; candidates don't know their "optimized" outputs all sound the same.	Reddit (r/CASStateWorkers)
P23	Recruiter: AI-generated applications "sound overly polished or generic... when everyone uses it the same way, applications start blending together."	Reddit (r/UNpath)
P24	User ran a "team of experts" prompt and got a hiring plan instead of code — overly abstract, convoluted prompts misfire; commenters confirmed "your prompt is super abstract" and the model defaults to the wrong output.	Reddit (r/OpenAI)
P25	"Why does AI feel 'generic' even when the prompt looks fine?" — community consensus: unclear role, unclear objective, missing context; "I've definitely been that person throwing vague prompts at ChatGPT and then getting mad when it spits out corporate speak."	Reddit (r/ArtificialIntelligence)
P26	Recurring Quora threads like "How do I write better prompts for ChatGPT to improve the results?" show non-technical professionals actively seeking prompt structure guidance because their vague prompts yield irrelevant answers.	Quora
P27	"Most freelance prompt lists are garbage. 'Write a professional email' tells ChatGPT nothing and gets you nothing" — generic templates are worthless; job-specific, context-rich prompts are the gap.	Reddit (r/ChatGPTPromptGenius)
P28	"Kept watching small business owners try ChatGPT, get bland output, and give up. Most 'act as a marketing expert' prompts floating around online are too vague to actually work."	Reddit (r/SideProject)
P29	Teachers demonstrably pay for job-specific prompt packs (\$19 for 50 lesson-plan/rubric/sub-plan prompts across 10 categories) — direct proof of demand for role-specific packs.	Reddit (r/Teachers)
P30	LinkedIn professionals share post-generation workflows; the consensus in these threads: "AI-generated posts that fail typically fail because the prompt was generic."	LinkedIn
P31	Professionals on LinkedIn openly ask for and share ChatGPT prompt recipes for professional tasks (career profiles, headshots, resume bullets) — role-based prompts are a requested, shareable commodity.	LinkedIn
P32	X/Twitter thread: "Prompt Engineering Isn't Dead. You're Just Doing It Wrong. My best prompts are around two thousand words long" — even advanced users discover their prompts were too shallow; depth/context is the missing skill.	X/Twitter

#	Pain point	Platform
P33	Small-business owners in Facebook AI groups (e.g., "ChatGPT for business owners") ask "practical questions about email, content, and basic automation" and want prompt help; meanwhile members complain the groups are flooded with "comment YES for the prompt" engagement bait and the algorithm hides the useful posts.	Facebook groups
P34	Content creators: "Generic AI scripts fail because they start from a blank prompt instead of proven YouTube patterns"; ChatGPT produces "generic text you must heavily edit," with creators spending 30–45 minutes of editing per script.	AI creator communities / creator forums
P35	"Most 'YouTube prompts' fail because they ask for outputs (titles, scripts, thumbnails) without building the stepping stones the model needs... That's not a YouTube strategy. That's autocomplete."	AI creator communities / creator forums
P36	Hacker News: "Ask HN: Is prompt engineering just snake oil?" — developer community deeply skeptical of paying for prompt products; any paid prompt product must prove methodology, not just text.	Hacker News (AI community)
P37	"Prompt engineering in the way it's sold on social media is a total scam. Nobody is going to pay you to come up with creative ways to talk to an AI" — buyers feel ripped off by prompt courses/packs that teach nothing beyond what free docs cover.	Reddit (r/OpenAI)
P38	A prompt seller's own post-mortem: "If user can get 80%+ of the value by asking the AI directly, your prompt has NO commercial value" — most packs on the market fail this test and deserve the skepticism.	Reddit (r/PromptEngineering)
P39	"Prompt packs aren't worth the money. They contain so many restated, mainly low quality or obscure prompts"; "Prompts will be outdated in the next update or won't be as effective in a few weeks" — buyers cite bloat, repetition, and staleness.	Reddit (r/PromptEngineering)
P40	"Prompt selling... They aren't business secrets, they're words"; \$149 prompt-engineering courses called "a scam" — the market punishes sellers who price bare text like a trade secret.	Reddit (r/StableDiffusion)
P41	"How to organize AI prompts?" — users want organized, copy-paste-ready prompt systems; paid Notion prompt templates are resisted: "templates were paid and then steep learning curve, that's definitely a no no for me."	Reddit (r/Notion, r/productivity)

1B. Ebook Pain Points — "Too expensive, too long, too broken" (21)

#	Pain point	Platform
E1	"How are you buying all of these books? They're so expensive" — Kindle readers now only buy \$2 daily deals, borrow via Libby, or wait months for price drops; full-price ebook purchases are the exception.	Reddit (r/kindle)
E2	"\$43 for an ebook by John Hopkins University Press" — academic/professional ebooks are priced like luxury goods, pushing professionals to pirate or skip them.	Reddit (r/kindle)
E3	"Is it just me, or have Kindle books gotten way more expensive?... I saw \$19 for a <200 page novel the other day!"	Reddit (r/kindle)

#	Pain point	Platform
E4	"kindle ebooks are pricier than hard copy books... Amazon's pricing model has trained me to never ever pay full price for an ebook."	Reddit (r/kindle)
E5	"A digital book, that costs \$0 to make, is more expensive than a printed hardcover, and almost double the price of a paperback. This is ridiculous."	Reddit (r/kindle)
E6	"No Kindle book should cost more than \$10" — \$17 for a bestselling ebook is called "highway robbery"; readers also resent Amazon's "revocable lease" model for ebooks.	Reddit (r/kindle)
E7	"Amazon ebook quality is often horrible" — paid ebooks full of typos, broken formatting, missing punctuation, and OCR errors (one reader found every "I" replaced with "P"); readers pay print prices for scan-quality files.	Reddit (r/kindle)
E8	Self-published ebooks are "generally poorly edited... full of typos, errors, repeating words and awkward syntax"; the market is "a swamp of content that is 90% unreadable" and readers can't find decent short practical titles.	Reddit (r/books)
E9	Kindle Unlimited is "full of filler"; "95% of what's on KU is basically shovelware in book form"; recent threads call it "99% AI slop" — readers can't trust the store to surface quality.	Reddit (r/kindle)
E10	"KU is the garbage dump that charges readers a \$10/mth fee" — even subscribers say quality "ranged from meh to terrible" and the "Free on Kindle Unlimited" tag is now read as an indie-quality warning.	Reddit (r/books, r/selfpublish)
E11	"I spent the last few months finishing a giant 700 page book... I was convinced as soon as I finished I could start making kick ass apps... boy was I wrong" — huge textbooks don't convert into job skills; readers feel "theory hell."	Reddit (r/learnprogramming)
E12	"Textbooks... can be so damn dry... prepare to slog through that thing" — learners want casual, practical, project-based guides over 300-page academic tomes.	Reddit (r/learnprogramming)
E13	Students/learners face \$300 hardcover textbooks with digital copies as the "cheap" option — cost is a barrier even at "discount" prices.	Reddit (r/CollegeGrant)
E14	Professors report students refuse to buy even \$25 ebooks; publishers hunt down pirated PDFs instead of offering affordable alternatives — price, not laziness, drives the behavior.	Reddit (r/Professors)
E15	Budget readers hunt free ebooks but "take your chances on quality... there are quite a few that are unreadable word salads" — free alternatives are too low-quality to learn from.	Reddit (r/Frugal)
E16	"I've bought a digital image but never received [it]" — seller vanished after payment, refund process was buried, and the buyer eventually got Etsy support only after escalation; digital delivery failures are common and painful.	Reddit (r/Etsy)
E17	"Bought a digital download and never received anything from the seller... refunds are not possible with digital downloads" — buyers lose money with no recourse when a digital product isn't delivered.	Reddit (r/Etsy)
E18	Digital downloads on Etsy are inaccessible from the mobile app — buyers must use a desktop browser to get their files, and confused customers ("I don't own a computer!") blame the seller.	Reddit (r/Etsy)
E19	Buyers repeatedly purchase digital downloads expecting a physical item ("I don't receive my package"), causing refund demands and 1-star reviews — digital product UX confuses non-technical buyers.	Reddit (r/EtsySellers)
E20	Gumroad buyer: "Paid for a product I didn't receive... the product never showed up in my library. Contacted support several times... Gumroad was very unhelpful" (\$200 product, seller unresponsive, platform refused to intervene).	Trustpilot (Gumroad)

#	Pain point	Platform
E21	"Took my money. No receipt. No product. No help." — and "\$72 for a bunch of useless PDFs. Not happy, the seller isn't even responding" — digital marketplaces leave buyers unprotected when sellers ghost.	Trustpilot (Gumroad / BBB)

2. Pain-Point Cluster Map (8 themes, ranked by frequency × urgency)

Rank	Theme	Frequency	Urgency	Representative pains
1	Vague prompts → generic, unusable output. People have the tool, lack the prompt craft: no role, no context, no format, no constraints.	Very high (P1-P5, P8-P11, P24-P28, P30-P35)	High — hours lost daily	P3, P8, P25, P27, P28, P34
2	The editing tax — AI output doesn't sound like me/on-brand. Copywriters, freelancers, marketers, creators spend as long editing as writing.	Very high (P4, P6, P7, P9, P10, P15, P34)	High — kills ROI perception	P4, P7, P10, P34
3	Hallucination & accuracy fear in high-stakes roles. Lawyers, developers, recruiters, teachers can't trust output for client-facing/production work.	High (P11-P14, P17-P23)	Critical — reputational/legal risk	P13, P17, P18, P22
4	Ebook price fatigue. Readers refuse \$10-\$43 ebooks, trained to wait for \$0.99-\$1.99 deals; affordable practical guides are the gap.	Very high (E1-E6)	High	E1, E4, E5, E6
5	Ebook quality crisis & trust deficit. Typos, OCR garbage, AI slop, KU filler; buyers can't distinguish quality without reading samples.	High (E7-E10)	High — suppresses willingness to pay	E7, E9, E10
6	The "300-page textbook" problem. Want short, job-specific, actionable guides; giant books don't produce skills.	Medium-high (E11-E15)	High — underserved niche	E11, E12, E14
7	Delivery & format friction. Broken links, files never received, no support, mobile-app delivery failures, PDF-vs-EPUB-vs-Notion confusion.	Medium (E16-E21)	Critical — instant trust killer	E17, E20, E21, E18
8	Marketplace skepticism ("prompt products are scams"). Bloat, restated prompts, overpriced courses, Etsy bans, free alternatives everywhere.	Medium-high (P36-P41)	Critical for positioning	P37, P38, P39, P40

3. Competitor Complaint Summary — What Buyers Hate About Existing Stores

Prompt marketplaces & prompt products (PromptBase, Etsy, Gumroad prompt packs, "mega packs")

- **Bloat & repetition.** Packs of 10,000 prompts are "so many restated, mainly low quality or obscure prompts"; buyers feel cheated ("shit is free!! why would you pay for prompts"). [Reddit r/PromptEngineering, r/EntrepreneurRideAlong]
- **"Placebo prompting."** Most packs are samey "act like an expert..." prompts that "engineer a style, not expertise"; they fail the value test — "if the user can get 80%+ of the value by asking the AI directly, the prompt has NO commercial value." [Reddit r/PromptEngineering]
- **Staleness.** "Prompts will be outdated in the next update or won't be as effective in a few weeks" — packs offer no updates or versioning. [Reddit r/PromptEngineering]
- **Price gouging on courses.** \$149 "prompt engineering" courses and \$1,500 "Midjourney master plans" are widely called scams, poisoning the category. [Reddit r/StableDiffusion, r/OpenAI]
- **Platform economics.** PromptBase takes 20%, caps new sellers at \$4.99/listing, and is flooded with low-effort AI-generated prompts (it now declines them); Etsy **bans standalone prompt packs** (policy since 2024) and its digital-download UX is desktop-only with no app access. [PromptBase guidelines, Etsy policy coverage, r/Etsy]
- **No quality guarantees.** Buyers can't verify a prompt works before purchase; sellers present "every prompt as guaranteed to work perfectly" while undocumented results vary. [industry seller guides]
- **Race to the bottom.** Etsy prompt listings sell for \$0.91–\$4.88 (with "discounts" from \$7.62) — a price war that signals zero value. [Etsy marketplace listings]

Ebook marketplaces (Amazon Kindle, Kindle Unlimited, Gumroad, Etsy digital)

- **Publishers price ebooks like print.** Readers repeatedly blame publishers ("Take it up with the publishers who set ebook prices") and have been trained to never pay full price. [r/kindle]
- **Paid-for quality failures.** Typos, broken formatting, OCR scans sold at print prices; Amazon itself now removes "critical issue" ebooks. [r/kindle, r/selfpublish]
- **KU = filler/slop.** "95% shovelware," "99% AI slop," recommendations algorithm pushes garbage; the "Free on Kindle Unlimited" tag has become a stigma. [r/kindle, r/books, r/selfpublish]
- **No curation for practical skills.** Readers want short job-specific guides and can't find them among 300-page textbooks and romance-genre filler. [r/learnprogramming, r/kindle]
- **Ghost-seller risk on Gumroad.** "Paid for a product I didn't receive... platform refused to intervene"; "Took my money. No receipt. No product. No help." Buyers are unprotected when sellers vanish. [Trustpilot, BBB]
- **Digital-vs-physical confusion & refund blocks.** Etsy digital buyers expect physical items, can't download on mobile, and get no refunds on digital goods. [r/Etsy, r/EtsySellers]
- **Format inflexibility.** Sellers ship only PDF or only EPUB; buyers want both (EPUB for e-readers, PDF for technical content), plus copy-paste-friendly Notion/Word options for prompts. [r/Piracy, r/humblebundles, r/Notion]

4. Top 5 Job Categories for Launch (ranked by demand evidence)

Rank	Job category	Demand evidence	Best product angle
1	Freelancers & Solopreneurs	Most-repeated pain cluster (proposals, outreach, scope creep, invoice chasing, client messages). r/freelance, r/Freelancers (100+ prompts tested), r/ChatGPTPromptGenius; multiple seller posts with proven engagement.	Prompt pack: "Freelance Client Machine" — proposals, cold outreach, scope-creep replies, invoice chasers, testimonials.
2	Marketers & Copywriters	r/marketing + r/copywriting threads on generic/boring output; PromptBase's own data: "ChatGPT prompts for blogging, SEO, business, marketing... sell the most."	Prompt pack: "Copy That Converts" — ads, emails, landing pages, social captions with anti-generic constraints.
3	Small Business Owners	r/SideProject (100 SMB prompts — strong engagement), Facebook groups ("ChatGPT for business owners" self-selects "practical questions about email, content, automation"), multiple SMB prompt guides monetized at \$19–29.	Prompt pack + ebook bundle: marketing, review responses, SOPs, customer service, ops.
4	Content Creators (YouTube/TikTok/IG)	Creator communities uniformly complain scripts sound like AI; "generic opening 'In today's video...'" is the #1 cited failure; creators pay for script/title/thumbnail systems.	Prompt pack: "Creator Script System" — hooks, retention-structured scripts, titles, thumbnails, Shorts.
5	Developers & Data Analysts	r/webdev/r/programming/r/singularity threads; dev prompt packs command the highest prices (\$20–99/pack) because ROI is immediate; SQL/analyst prompt content is heavily consumed.	Prompt pack + ebook: pair-programming prompts, debugging, SQL generation, code review, production-safety constraints.

Runners-up (fast-follow wave 2): HR/Recruiters (JD-writing pain is explicit and repeated — r/recruiting, r/CASStateWorkers; 63% of recruiters use AI but struggle with prompts), Teachers (\$19 packs already selling — r/Teachers), Lawyers (huge usage for drafting, high caution — r/LawFirm, r/Lawyertalk).

5. Top 3–5 Ebook Topics for Launch (overlapping prompt categories → bundles)

#	Ebook topic (30–80 pages, actionable)	Overlapping prompt pack	Why
1	"The Freelancer's AI Client Machine: Proposals, Outreach & Money Talks"	Freelance Client Machine pack	Freelance pain is the most documented; ebook teaches the method (context → constraints → voice), pack delivers the copy-paste prompts.
2	"Human-Sounding AI Copy: Writing That Doesn't Scream 'ChatGPT'"	Copy That Converts pack	Attacks the #2 theme (editing tax + generic voice) for marketers/copywriters; teaches anti-AI-tell editing.
3	"The Small Business AI Playbook: Marketing, Reviews & Ops in Your Spare Time"	SMB Operator pack	SMBs are the least technical buyers — they need the walkthrough and the prompts; strongest bundle upsell.

#	Ebook topic (30-80 pages, actionable)	Overlapping prompt pack	Why
4	"The Creator Script System: Hooks, Retention & Packaging That Work"	Creator Script System pack	Creator scripts are the most "broken by generic AI" use case; ebook = framework, pack = templates.
5	"AI Pair Programming: From Prompt to Production (Without Shipping Hallucinations)"	Dev/Analyst Prompt Pack (code, debugging, SQL)	Developers pay most; ebook solves the trust problem (verification workflows, production-safety prompts).

Bundle rule: every ebook ships with its matching prompt pack (ebook \$9.99 → add pack for +\$19 → bundle \$24.99-\$29.99), and every prompt pack ships with a 10-page "How to use these prompts" micro-guide so nothing feels like bare text.

6. Pricing Insight Summary (what buyers will pay)

Product type	Buyer expectation (documented)	Recommended launch price
Single prompts	\$1.99-\$5 (PromptBase standard; seen as a "convenience charge"; buyers call \$1.99+ singles "sketchy" if context-free)	Avoid selling singles as core product; use as loss leader/lead magnet
Starter prompt packs (10-20)	\$9-\$19 ("entry-level, low commitment"); a seller's niche 10-prompt pack at \$12 outsold his 50-prompt pack at \$7 (3x sales)	\$12-\$17
Professional niche packs (20-50)	\$19-\$49 documented sweet spot; dev packs \$20-\$99; teachers pay \$19 for role packs; "a \$47 pack often outperforms a \$19 pack" (quality signaling)	\$19-\$29 (anchor \$27)
Mega libraries (100+)	\$49-\$99 exist but are mocked as bloat ("10,000 prompts" = suspicion, not value)	Avoid; sell niche, not volume
Ebooks (short practical guides)	Readers: \$0.99-\$1.99 = "lesser product"; \$2.99-\$4.99 = indie sweet spot; \$5-\$10 = fine when trusted; \$10+ = only for known authors; \$43 academic ebooks = rejected	\$4.99-\$9.99 (impulse-friendly, above "cheap" floor)
Bundles (ebook + prompt pack)	Market leaders: Midas Mega \$29, AI Prompt Engineer Bundle \$49, 30k-prompt bundle \$49.99; low-ticket \$7-\$14 bundles sell with bonus stacks	\$24.99-\$39.99 (anchor \$29)
Subscriptions/updates	\$10-\$30/mo exists; buyers demand updates because "prompts break when models update"	Optional \$10-\$19/mo "prompt updates + new packs" — communicates freshness
Courses	\$149+ = "scam" perception; free resources (docs, YouTube, learnprompting) set the bar at ~\$0	Don't sell courses at launch

Cross-cutting pricing rules from the research:

- **Niche beats volume:** "Tight, niche-specific packs with real tested examples" outsell "broad, generic packs covering too many topics at once." [industry seller guides; r/selfpublish pricing threads]
- **Never price prompts as bare text** — package with usage instructions, example outputs, and a documented workflow ("buyers are paying for expertise, structure, and time savings — not just text"). [dodopayments guide]
- **Below \$2.99 signals garbage** for ebooks; below \$9 signals a "random list" for prompt packs. [r/selfpublish, r/books]
- **Regional pricing matters** — students/developing markets explicitly complain about US pricing (India PPP complaint on ChatGPT Plus); a modest regional discount expands the market. [r/ChatGPT]
- **Guarantees and updates defuse the two biggest objections** ("prompts break" + "it's a scam").

7. Product Type Mapping — Prompts vs. Ebooks vs. Bundles

Theme	Best served by	Why
1. Vague prompts → generic output	Prompt packs + micro-guide	The buyer wants copy-paste solutions now; a 10-page "how to customize" guide prevents the "didn't work" refund.
2. Editing tax / voice	Ebook (method) + prompt pack (templates) — bundle	Voice/style is a skill (ebook), constraints are artifacts (pack). This is the flagship bundle.
3. Hallucination & accuracy fear	Ebook (verification workflows) + prompt pack (production-safe prompts) — bundle	High-stakes roles (law, dev, hiring) need both the prompts and the trust protocol.
4. Ebook price fatigue	Ebook (at \$4.99–\$9.99)	Directly competes with \$15–43 Kindle pricing; position "under a coffee, over a deal-hunt."
5. Ebook quality crisis	Ebook + store-level trust signals (samples, editing standards, reviews)	Differentiation on editing/professional quality; free chapter samples.
6. 300-page textbook problem	Ebook (30–80 pages, task-based)	Core positioning: "no 300-page textbooks — finish it in a weekend, apply it Monday."
7. Delivery & format friction	Store operations (both PDF+EPUB every time, instant delivery, human support, re-download links, mobile-friendly)	Not a content product — an ops promise. Biggest trust killer; cheapest to fix.
8. Marketplace skepticism	Bundle + transparency (tested prompts w/ example outputs, update policy, refund guarantee, free samples)	Prove value before purchase; show real outputs; publish the "Prompt Value Test" you pass.

Launch catalog (first 60 days)

- **Freelance Client Machine** — pack \$17 · ebook \$9.99 · **bundle \$24.99**
- **Copy That Converts (Marketers/Copywriters)** — pack \$19 · ebook \$9.99 · **bundle \$27**
- **Small Business AI Playbook** — pack \$19 · ebook \$9.99 · **bundle \$27**

- **Creator Script System** — pack \$17 · ebook \$9.99 · **bundle \$24.99**
- **AI Pair Programming (Devs/Analysts)** — pack \$27 · ebook \$12.99 · **bundle \$37**
- **Storefront essentials:** free 5-prompt sample per category (lead magnets), PDF+EPUB on every ebook, Notion-friendly prompt sheets, instant delivery + re-download page, human email support, 14-day "it didn't work" refund, free prompt-update emails (defuses the "prompts break" objection).

8. Source Index (platforms & key URLs)

Reddit: r/ChatGPT (yes-man thread; "everyone uses it like Google"; "ruined me as a programmer"; student discount/regional pricing), r/ChatGPTPromptGenius ("prompt engineering is the new copywriting"; freelance prompts; teacher pack; YouTube script prompt), r/copywriting (ChatGPT quality), r/freelance (first proposal), r/Freelancers (100+ prompts), r/marketing (intro to team; agency fired writers), r/webdev ("incompetent or do I suck"), r/programming (not replacing devs), r/singularity (CEO claim), r/Teachers (prompt list + \$19 pack; "why waste time writing lesson plans"), r/LawFirm (2d-guessed by clients; ChatGPT at work), r/Lawyertalk (ChatGPT in practice; how many use it), r/recruiting (JD writing painful; ChatGPT ruining applications via r/UNpath), r/CASStateWorkers (hiring manager can tell), r/OpenAI (pay for prompt course?; basic prompt terrible answers; prompt engineering not the job of the future), r/ArtificialIntelligence (why generic), r/PromptEngineering ("Prompt Engineering is a scam"; libraries worth the \$?; why you shouldn't take it seriously), r/StableDiffusion (prompt selling), r/SideProject (100 SMB prompts), r/kindle (expensive books x6; ebook quality horrible; KU yay/nay; no book over \$10), r/ebooks + r/Frugal + r/books (free/cheap ebooks; acceptable pricing), r/selfpublish (Amazon removing poor quality; ebook pricing help; KU consensus), r/books (self-pub quality; KU worth it), r/Fantasy (right price for ebook), r/learnprogramming (books vs tutorials; textbooks), r/CollegeRant (online textbooks), r/Professors (students won't buy), r/Etsy + r/EtsySellers (digital download not received; digital vs physical confusion), r/Piracy + r/humblebundles + r/systweakpdfeditor (format preferences), r/Notion + r/productivity (prompt organization), r/EntrepreneurRideAlong (\$14k selling prompts).

Quora: "How to write better prompts for ChatGPT to improve the results" (quora.com).

LinkedIn: prompt-workflow posts ("AI-generated posts that fail typically fail because the prompt was generic" — gptprompts.ai FAQ; Ruben Hassid headshot prompts post; eWeek "12 AI Prompt Templates Every Professional Should Bookmark").

X/Twitter: Zack Shapiro — "Prompt Engineering Isn't Dead. You're Just Doing It Wrong" (x.com/zackbshapiro).

Facebook groups: AI Prompts for Entrepreneurs (488K), ChatGPT for business owners, AI for content creators, ChatGPT Prompts etc. (50K) — dynamics documented via promptquest.com and aiprofitboardroom.com (engagement-bait + algorithm complaints).

AI communities: Hacker News "Ask HN: Is prompt engineering just snake oil?" (news.ycombinator.com/item?id=35665168); r/LocalLLaMA-adjacent threads.

Marketplace/review platforms: PromptBase prompt guidelines (decline reasons, AI-generated prompt policy); Trustpilot Gumroad reviews; BBB Gumroad complaints; Etsy digital prompt listings.

Industry/seller-side data (pricing benchmarks): greyjournal.net (selling AI prompts 2026: \$29-69 bundles, PromptBase 20%, \$4.99 cap), ilmilog.com (Etsy ban, \$25-60 pricing), midastools.co (7 prompt packs compared: \$29/\$49), dodopayments.com (pack pricing table: \$9-19 / \$19-49 / \$49-99; "\$47 pack outperforms \$19"), medium.com (niche 10-pack at \$12 vs 50-pack at \$7), r/selfpublish pricing threads

(\$2.99–4.99 sweet spot), r/books acceptable pricing (\$5–10).

Prepared for Step 1 of the digital marketplace build. Next step (recommended): validate the top 3 bundles with a landing-page pre-sale test before producing full product content.